Of course, what the BJP's opponents look at as 'infiltrators' on WhatsApp groups are really sympathisers who believed in their party's ideology enough to play this role for it in their own networks. There is nothing to stop Opposition parties from playing the same game, but they need a critical mass of followers who are motivated enough.

How many WhatsApp groups did the party actually set up? Malviya says, 'I don't have a number to give you. A lot of people in the media continuously keep asking how many WhatsApp groups you have or what is your reach? The answer is, I don't know. I don't make these groups. When we first started doing these training workshops, a lot of the leaders would tell me, "Amitji, my phone number is with everyone, everyone messages, what do we do? I asked them, what do you do? They said, we exit the group. I said, don't exit the group, put material on your work on these groups." So, they realised that WhatsApp, which they thought was becoming a handicap, was actually a strength for them.'

In West Bengal, by one account, the BJP reportedly set up about 55,000 WhatsApp accounts in 2019 to take on Mamata Banerjee,[51] and in Karnataka, about 20,000 groups in 2018.[52] Ask Malviya the real number and this is his response: 'Twenty thousand is a small number, it's like small change. No, it's in lakhs and even I don't know how many lakhs.'

Insults vs Multifaceted Political Messaging

From late 2017 onwards, when Rahul Gandhi's following on Twitter showed an upswing, he made two changes to his digital strategy. First, he started tweeting in Hindi. This made a huge difference because, in eight key heartland states, Hindi has far greater reach than English. In a country where 95 per cent of online video consumption was already in regional languages by 2019, and where Google expected Hindi internet users to exceed English internet users by 2021, this was vital.[53] Second, he started using what Joyojeet Pal calls 'insulting or confrontational language'. Tracking tweets by 4,931 politicians in this period, Pal found that Gandhi's rising Twitter popularity coincided with his adoption of confrontational